



Building Local Collaboration Through the Lawrence Partnership for Transition to Employment

Massachusetts APSE: Employment Matters
Building Your Network
2024 Conference
College of the Holy Cross, Worcester, MA

October 10, 2024



**Institute for
Community
Inclusion**

Agenda

- Introduction to the LPTE
- Community Perspectives on Transition:
 - Nichelle Delgado shares her transition journey
 - Herb Cabral shares his thoughts on transition as a parent
 - Community Landscape Analysis findings
- Next Steps for the LPTE
- Q & A



About the LPTE

The Lawrence Partnership for Transition to Employment (**LPTE**) was **established in 2021** under a **5-year grant** from the Administration for Community Living (ACL) as a National Center of Excellence on **Community Collaborations for Employment**.

The project aims to **improve the transition process** for youth with intellectual and developmental disabilities (ID/DD) in **Lawrence**, Massachusetts.



Lawrence, Massachusetts: Ciudad Latina

“Latinos were responsible for reversing the city’s population decline: for filling its abandoned homes and buildings; for bringing life to its streets, churches, restaurants, and parks; and for anchoring its tax base. There can be no doubt that Latino migration was good for the city of Lawrence.” (Barber, 2017, p. 217)



Barber, L. (2017). *Latino City: Immigration and Urban Crisis in Lawrence, Massachusetts, 1945–2000*. University of North Carolina Press.

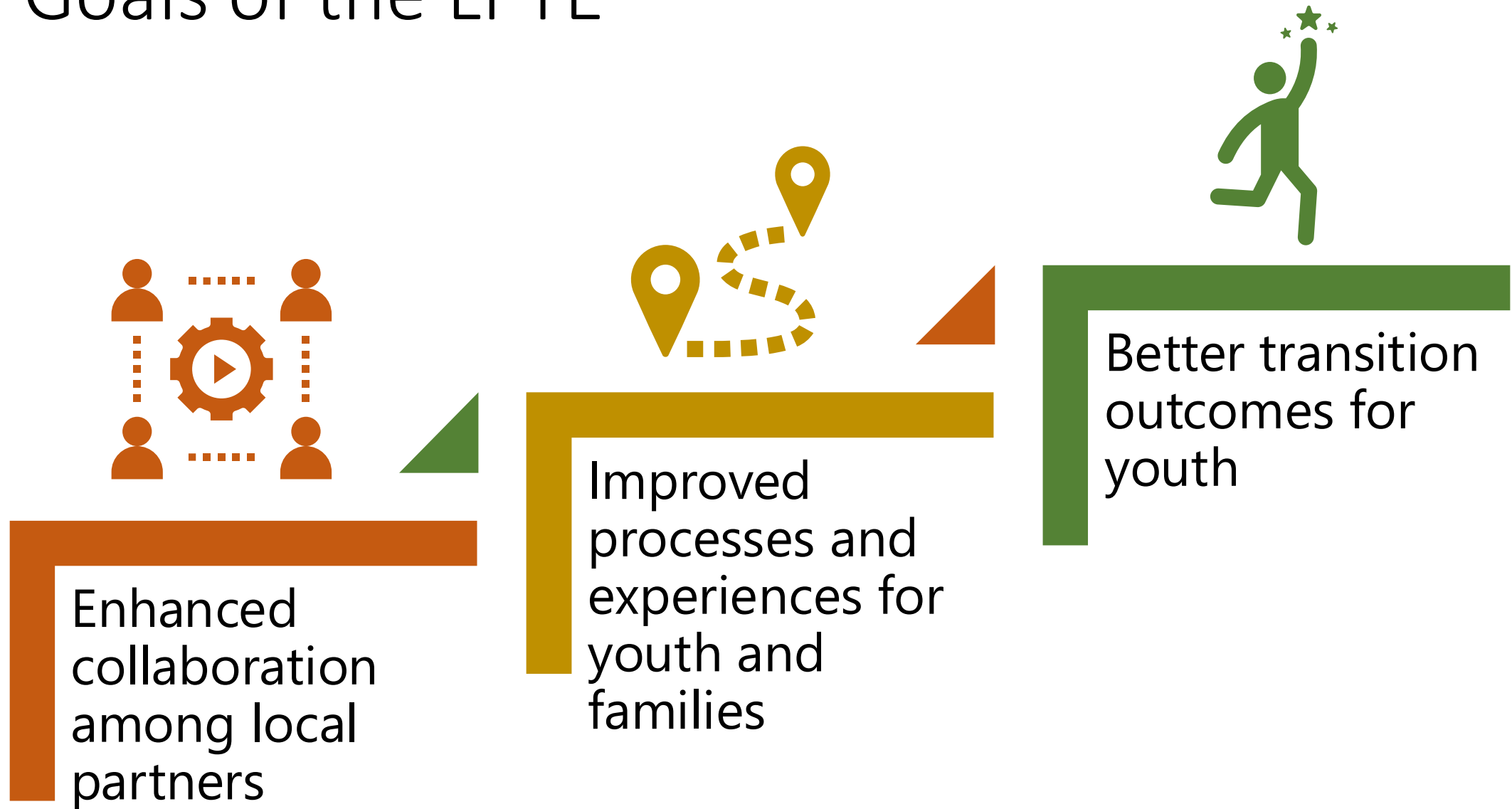
Map source: Alexrk2, CC BY 3.0 via Wikimedia Commons

https://upload.wikimedia.org/wikipedia/commons/7/79/USA_Massachusetts_location_map.svg

Photo of Ayer Mill source: Marcbela (Marc N. Belanger), Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons,

https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Ayer_Mill_View.jpg

Goals of the LPTE

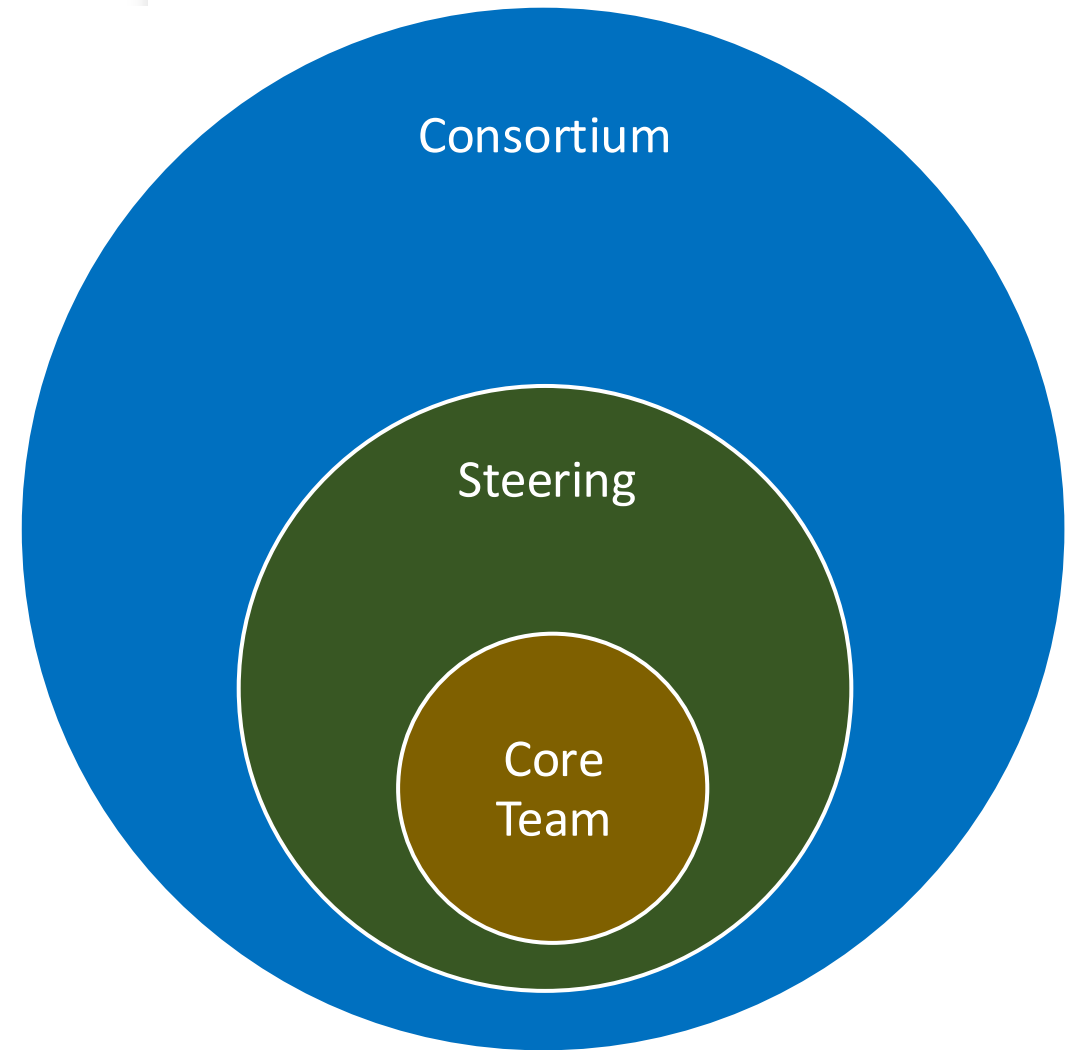


6 Principles of Collaborating for Equity & Justice

The six principles are:	LPTE will:
1. Directly address race, ethnicity, and social class.	Talk openly about these things, starting with this meeting.
2. Give equal power to community members in deciding what's important to work on.	Listen to parents, students, and other people in Lawrence when deciding what to put in our strategic plan.
3. Work to build leadership and power among community members.	Include parents and students as paid team members in all project work.
4. Focus on changing whole systems, not just local programs.	Learn from people in Lawrence how state and national policies can be better for families.
5. Look to research on what works.	Use existing tools to measure how we are doing.
6. Support the group members to lead the work.	Use ICI and Arc staff to support what the consortium wants to do.

LPTE Structure

- **Consortium** (90 members, 40+ active)
 - Meets quarterly
 - Guides overall work of the project
- **Steering Committee** (12 members)
 - Meets monthly
 - Established the CLA process
 - Consults on logistical details
 - Discusses emerging themes
- **Core Team** (4 members)
 - Meets weekly



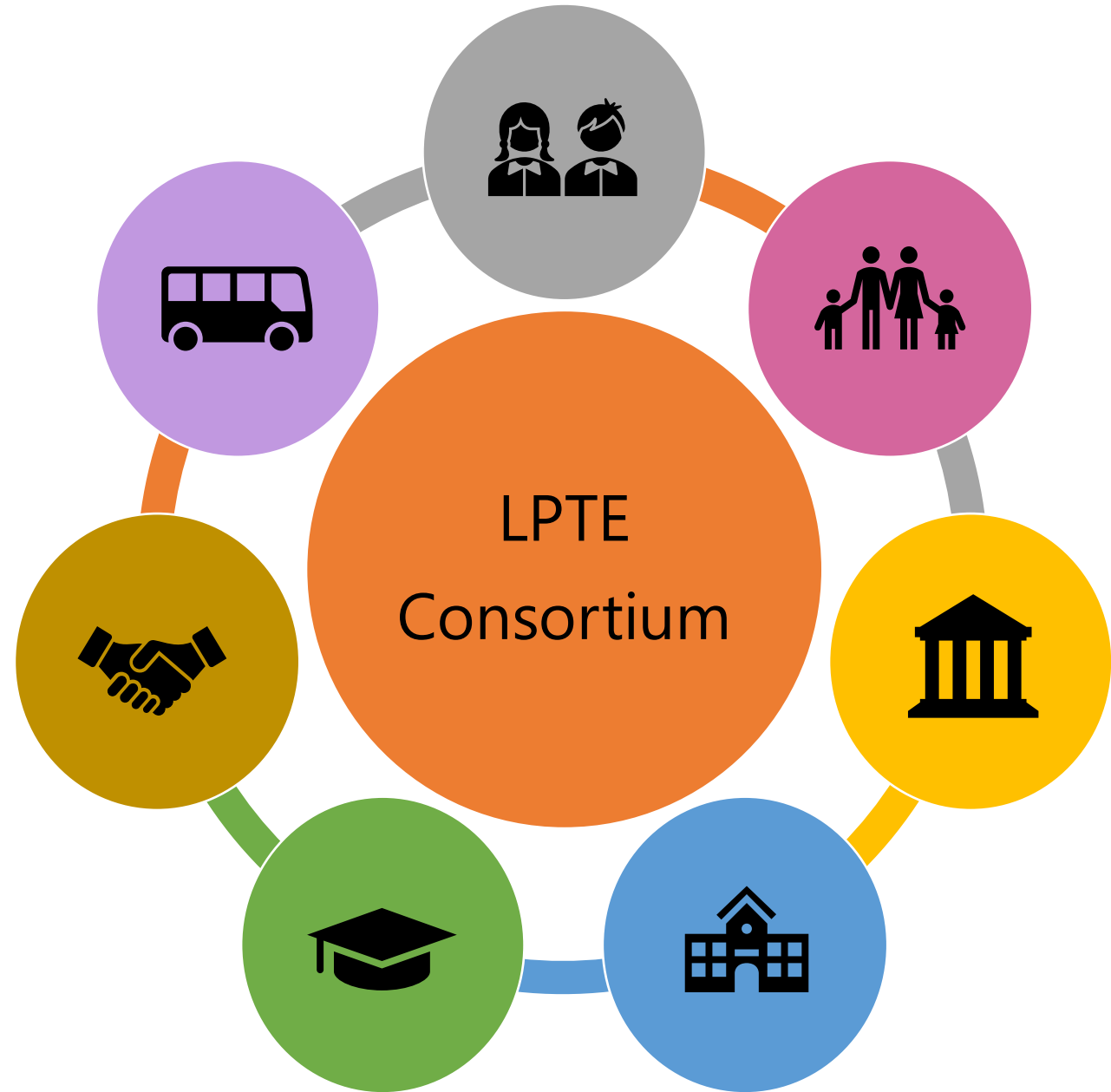
Who are the members of the LPTE Consortium?

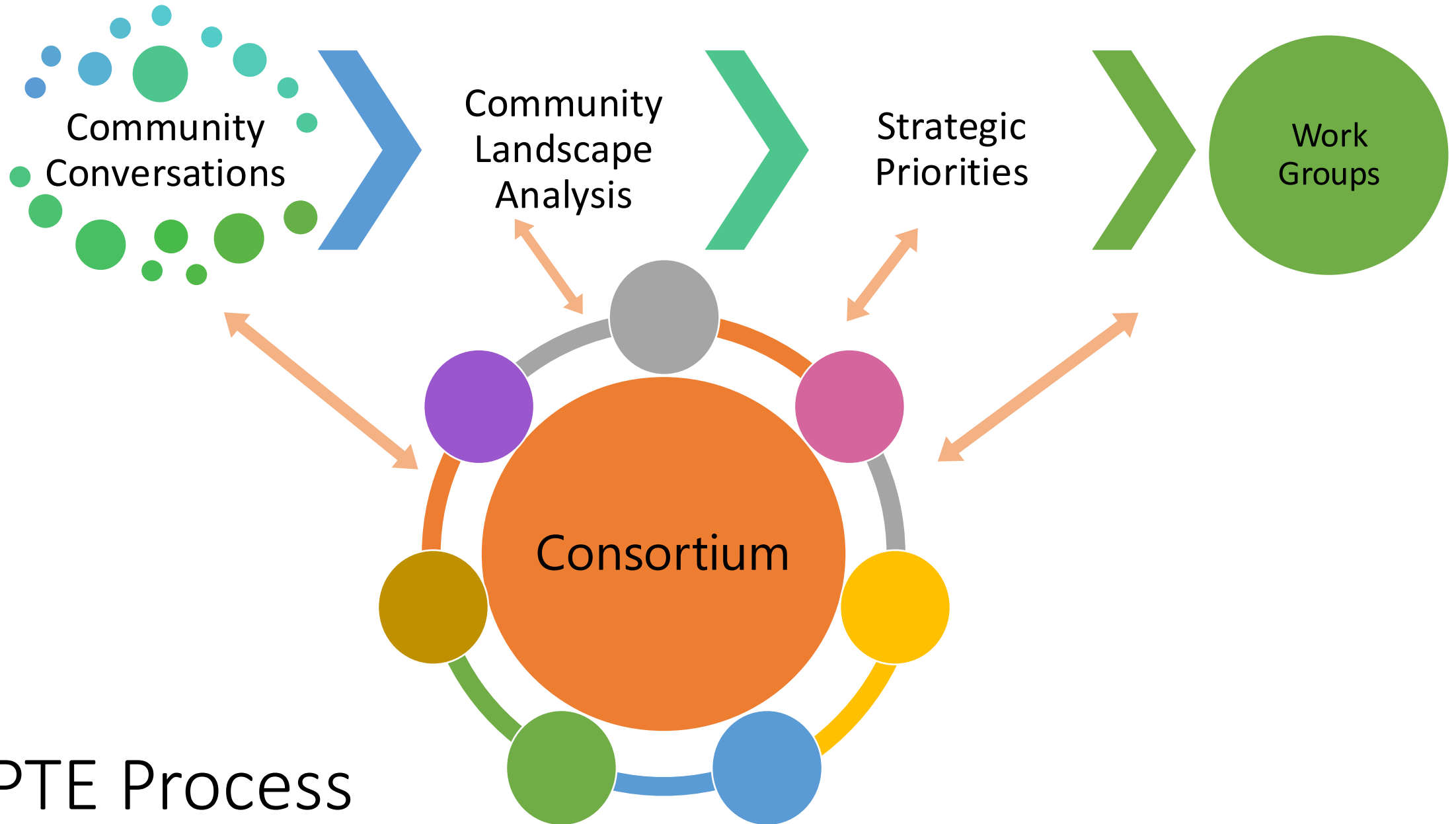
Local:

- Self-advocates and parents/families
- Mayor's office, ADA coordinator
- Public schools, community college
- Family advocacy groups
- Employment collaborative
- Independent Living Center
- Local nonprofits

State and regional:

- Workforce Center
- Social Security
- Department of Developmental Services
- State VR agency
- Regional transportation authority
- Children's advocacy center





LPTE Process

Community Conversations

Community conversations were held to gather perspectives of community members. We asked:

1. What **outcomes** are important for youth with disabilities in Lawrence when they leave school?
2. What 1 or 2 things would **help youth with disabilities find employment** when they leave school?
3. What 1 or 2 **strengths in the Lawrence community** could help youth with disabilities find employment?
4. In 4 years, what **services, supports, and opportunities** for work **would you like to see** for youth with disabilities in your community?



Perspectives from the Community

Nichelle Delgado, Peer Advocate

Herb Cabral, Parent Advocate

Community Landscape Analysis Results

Nichelle Delgado shares her transition journey



My Advocacy Life

Nichelle Delgado's Story



WELCOME!

I live in Lawrence. I work with the Arc of Greater Haverhill Newburyport as a peer support mentor.

I would like to talk to you about my story and teach you why it is important to speak up!

What I will cover today.

A little about me.

Why I am here.

My Story

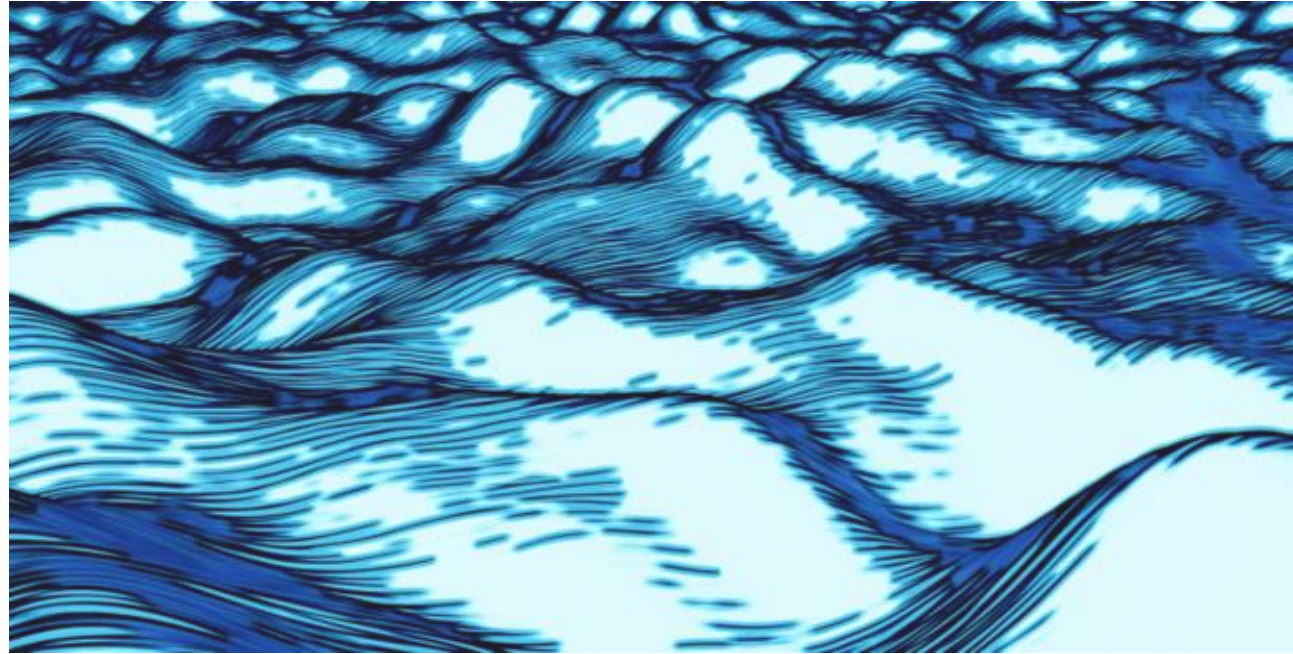
What you can do

Thank you & Questions

A little about me.

Here I am for my visit to the State House in Boston for the Arc Mass Legislative Reception. This was my first time visiting our State House!





A few fun facts. I Love Swimming
I Love the Beach
I have Bearded Dragons

My Babies



Why I am here!

I want students to feel inspired to speak up and make their own destiny, make their own future!

**I AM
THE MASTER OF
MY FATE AND
THE CAPTAIN OF
MY DESTINY.**

- Nelson Mandela



I want everyone to
know this message!
Love your disability.
I accept my Autism
because it made me
who I am, and I am
proud of Who I Am.



My Life is A Journey

It's like an open
book. I can make
the best of it. You
can too!



Growing up

I lived in Haverhill and went to the Haverhill Public Schools. I lived with my mother, my brother, Mike, and my pet cat, Leon. Here I am swimming with my family.



Living in Washington State

- When I was 11 my mother, brother, my cat and I moved to Washington State. It wasn't easy for me. I was far away from my Aunt & Grandmother and what I loved out here.
- Here's Mt. Hood, a mountain I could see from my home in Washington . It reminds me of the Paramount Picture logo. It's cool, majestic, very beautiful. This reminds me of what it's like in the Pacific Northwest.



This Photo by Unknown Author is licensed under [CC BY-NC-ND](#)

Coming back to Massachusetts

- When I was 15 my brother and I came back to Lawrence to live with my Grandmother. My mom was having a hard time financially and we were living with a friend. We got evicted from our apartment. My mom was worried because she didn't want us living in a friend's apartment. She made the decision it would be best for us to live with my Grandmother. It was especially hard for me. I was worried because my mom was alone.
- We planned to go back out there but it didn't happen.



The image shows the exterior of a multi-story brick building, identified as Lawrence High School. The name "LAWRENCE HIGH SCHOOL" is carved in large, capital letters across the upper facade. Below the name, there is a set of stairs leading to a large blue double door. The building has many windows, some with blue shutters. A small sign is visible in the bottom right corner.

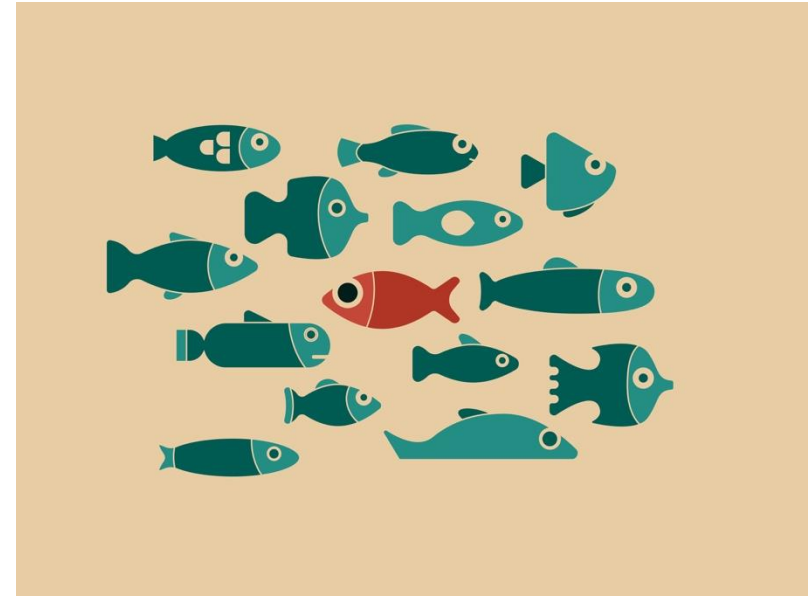
LAWRENCE HIGH SCHOOL

School for Exceptional Studies High School & Beyond

- **When I was in high school, I didn't speak up because I thought I would get in trouble.**
- **I felt like I had to do what they recommended.**
- **I didn't want to stay at school until I was 22 and I didn't understand it. I felt upset and like I didn't have a choice.**



Ups and downs after High School



- Trying a job at a daycare
- Going to a summer program & doing an internship
- My Aunt suggested I go to a day program
- Feeling stuck, bored, depressed.

My hopes for students.

- It's important to really listen to what students want and include them in the decision making about their lives.



Why it's important to use my voice.

- Advocating to leave a program that wasn't right for me. I had to do it. It's hard but I had to do it.



My Life Now



I live in Lawrence with my Grandmother and brother. My mom still lives in Washington State, and she comes out to visit us every August. She is coming soon and I can't wait to hug her and tell her how much I missed her.

This year I traveled to see her on my own for the first time ever!

- I teach other people how to speak up and make a life for themselves!

Peer Support

Gain confidence
Help each other
Educate ourselves
Create friendships
Use Your Voice to get what
you need



Since 2018 I was going to a mobile day program. I liked that it was a smaller group and less stress. It was supposed to get us ready to eventually work. For the first few years I thought it was pretty cool. It was interesting to see different places in the community.

- This year I decided to leave the program because the rules changed, and we couldn't be as independent or flexible. It was no longer accommodating and certain people made the group unenjoyable. I was worrying my depression might come back. So I decided to stop this program. I learned about self direction and to do what I want to do. I'm too independent but there are still things I want to learn.



Making
changes in
my supports
to fit my life
now.



My goals: Cooking, driving, membership at the YMCA, therapeutic horseback riding

I want to be more in control of my life and do what I want to do. I want to go where I want to go in the future. So now I am planning to do SELF DIRECTION.

Keys to my independence

- I use public transportation to get to work at the Arc of Greater Haverhill Newburyport, go to appointments, and do all kinds of fun activities. I know how to use the bus, Lyft and Mini Meva to get where I want to go!



What you can to support students to have a great life!



- What is one dream you had as a young person?

- Think of someone who supported your dream. What did they do? How did they act?

New Youth Group in September -- Destiny

This group is a place to gain confidence, help each other and learn to use your voice.




The Arc
Greater Haverhill-Newburyport

**Youth
GROUP**

AGES 18-26

SAVE THE DATE!
SEPTEMBER 10TH
4:30PM-6:00PM

**LEARN HOW TO USE YOUR VOICE, PROBLEM SOLVE,
MAKE FRIENDS, HAVE FUN! BEGIN TO CREATE YOUR
OWN FUTURE AND KNOW YOU ARE NOT ALONE!**

HC Media, 60 Elm St, Haverhill

RSVP to Bridget Crowley at bcrowley@thearcofghn.org

Thank you for listening!
Do you have any questions
or comments? Contact us:
bcrowley@thearcofghn.org
978-373-0552 x210

Nichelle Delgado
Peer Support Mentor
The Arc of Greater Haverhill
Newburyport



Herb Cabral, Parent Advocate





Thoughts on Transition

Herb Cabral

10/10/2024

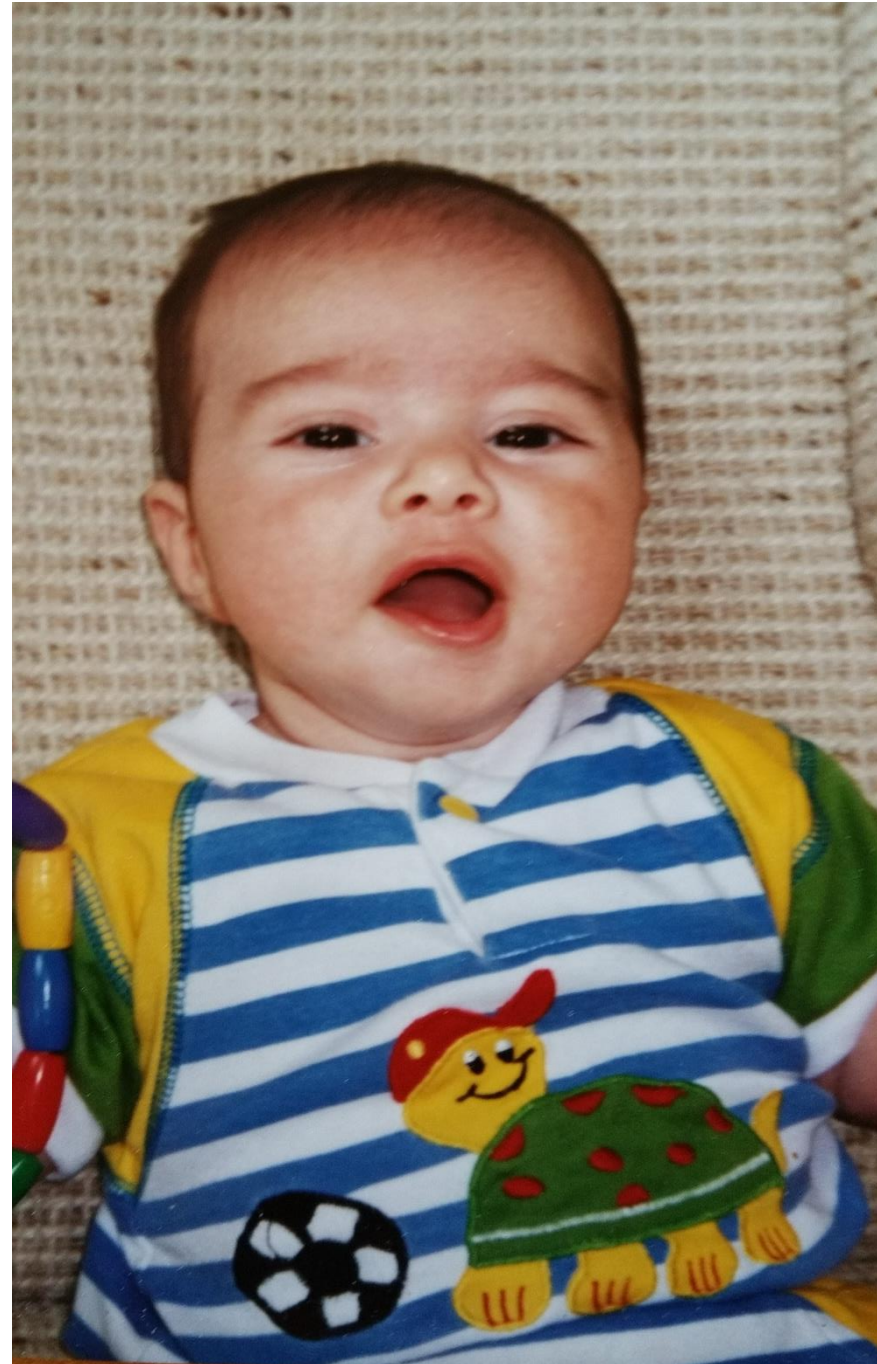
Build a Team

- Family
- Friends
- School
- Caregivers
- Medical Professionals
- Legislators
- Community
- Person Centered



Start Early

- Understand the Diagnosis
- Learn the Process
- Early Intervention, Schools, Adult Services
- Capabilities, Likes/Dislikes, Environments
- Engage Others in the process (PCP)



Know Your Resources

- School – IEP, TPF
- Insurance
- Benefits – Federal, State
 - Soc Sec
 - DDS
- Community
- Technology

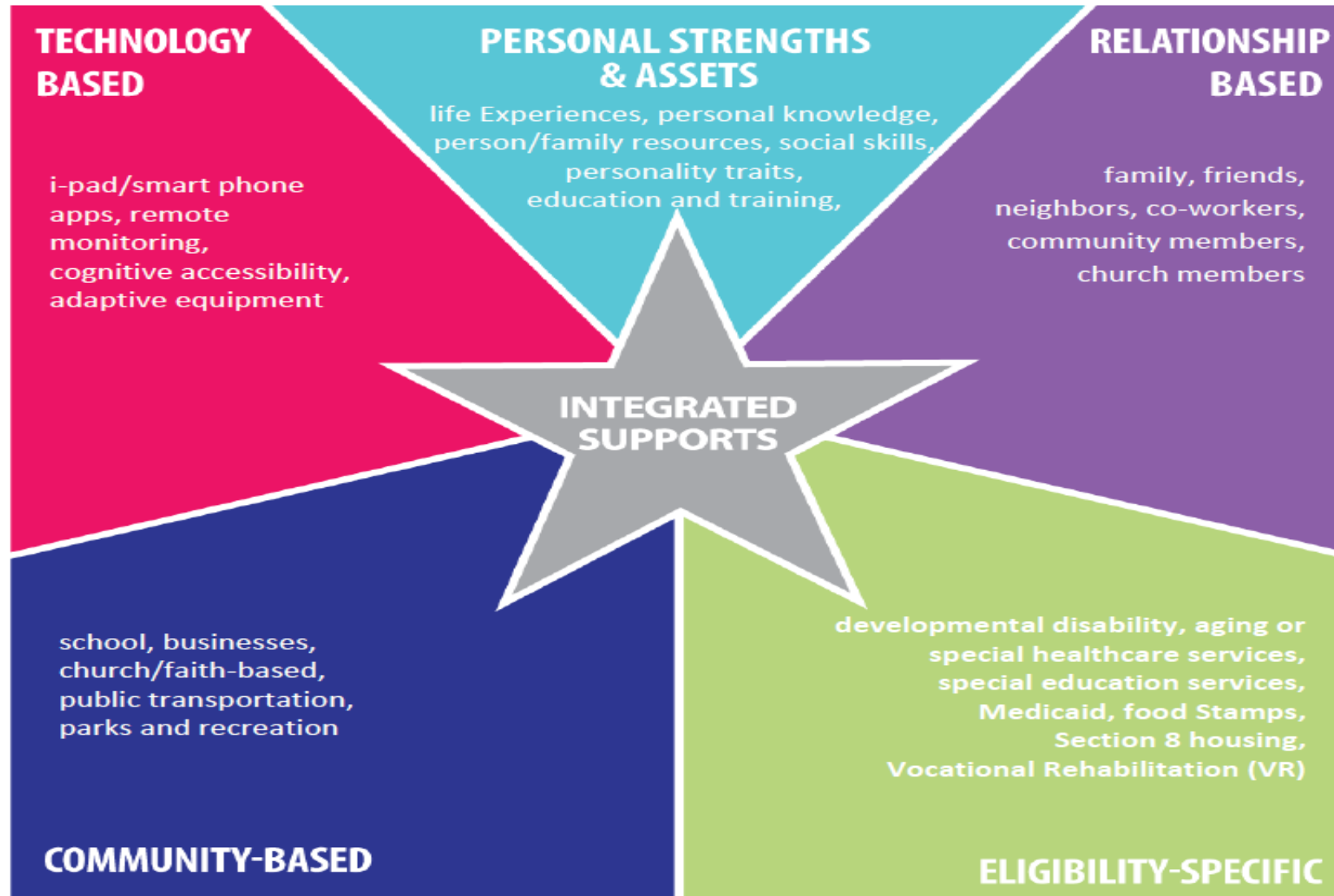


Have a Plan

- School
- Community
- Medical
- Employment
- Housing
- Schedule
- Finances
- Estate



Tools - Charting The Life Course



Legislative Advocacy

Know Your Government

Community

State

Federal

Communication/Visits

State Budget Process

Legislation/Bills



Storytelling

- Who is your audience?
- What has taken place
 - Events
 - Timeline
- What do you need them to do?
- Follow Up!



Community Landscape Analysis (CLA): Summary of Findings

1. Most **important outcomes** for youth with disabilities in Lawrence.
2. **Strengths of the community** that can be an asset to transitioning youth.
3. Recommended **strategies** for the LPTE



1. Most Important Outcomes for Youth

- **Identifying and working toward their own goals**
- **Competitive Integrated Employment**
- **Community engagement and relationships**
- **Gaining skills**
- **Ongoing supports**
- **Having a team like they did in school**
- **Champion, coach, or mentor (professional or family/friend)**

2. Strengths of the Community

- **Community values and culture**
- **Disability services**
- **Community resources**
- **Local businesses**
- **Engaged parents and family members**
- **Personal strengths of youth with disabilities**



3. Strategic Priorities: LPTE Work Groups

- Develop and implement plans for the next 3 years
- Led by Consortium members (including a chair or co-chairs)
- Supported by a staff facilitator
- Meet monthly
- Report out at quarterly consortium meetings

**Improve the
handoff and
foster better
cross-agency
connections**

**Offer more
work
experiences
while in
school**

**Prepare
students for
other
aspects of
adult life**

**Partner with
families**



Next Steps: Building the LPTE Resource Hub

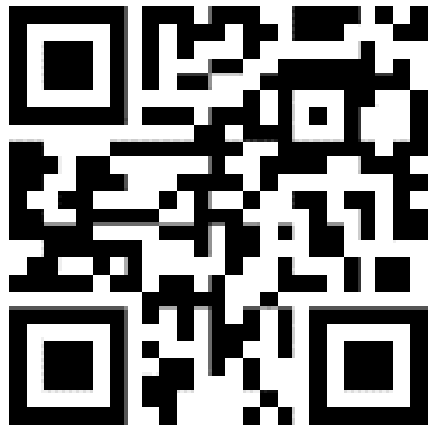
- An online resource hub that collects links to all of Lawrence's transition resources into one place
- The resource hub will also contain a walkthrough that will help guide students and parents through the transition process
- We hope to have the hub ready for beta testing by spring/summer 2025!





Interested in joining the LPTE?

- The LPTE would welcome more involvement from students, parents and business owners in the Lawrence area!
- We have funds to pay students and parents for their time!
- See the following slide for contact information or go to **LPTE.info** for more information!



Contact

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The contents of this presentation were developed under a grant from the Administration for Community Living (ACL), U.S. Department of Health and Human Services (HHS) (CFDA:93.631). The contents are those of the authors and do not necessarily represent the official views of, nor an endorsement by, ACL/HHS or the U.S. Government.



LPTE.inf



Questions?

